

9

Underlying Competencies

The Underlying Competencies chapter provides a description of the behaviours, characteristics, knowledge, and personal qualities that support the practice of business analysis.

The underlying competencies described here are not unique to business analysis. They are described here to ensure readers are aware of the range of fundamental skills required and provide a basis for them to further investigate the skills and knowledge that will enable them to be accomplished and adaptable business analysts.

These competencies are grouped into six categories:

- Analytical Thinking and Problem Solving (p. 188),
- Behavioural Characteristics (p. 194),
- Business Knowledge (p. 199),
- Communication Skills (p. 203),
- Interaction Skills (p. 207), and
- Tools and Technology (p. 211).

Each underlying competency is defined with a purpose, definition, and effectiveness measures.

9.1 Analytical Thinking and Problem Solving

Analytical thinking and problem solving skills are required for business analysts to analyze problems and opportunities effectively, identify which changes may deliver the most value, and work with stakeholders to understand the impact of those changes.

Business analysts use analytical thinking by rapidly assimilating various types of information (for example, diagrams, stakeholder concerns, customer feedback, schematics, user guides, and spreadsheets), and identifying which are relevant. Business analysts should be able to quickly choose effective and adaptable methods to learn and analyze the media, audiences, problem types, and environments as each is encountered.

Business analysts utilize analytical thinking and problem solving as they facilitate understanding of situations, the value of proposed changes, and other complex ideas.

Possessing a sound understanding of the analytical thinking and problem solving core competencies allows business analysts to identify the best ways to present information to their stakeholders. For example, some concepts are more easily understood when presented in diagrams and information graphics rather than by paragraphs of text. Having this understanding assists business analysts when planning their business analysis approach and enables them to communicate business analysis information in a manner that suits the material being conveyed to their audience.

Analytical Thinking and Problem Solving core competencies include:

- Creative Thinking,
- Decision Making,
- Learning,
- Problem Solving,
- Systems Thinking,
- Conceptual Thinking, and
- Visual Thinking.

9.1.1 Creative Thinking

.1 Purpose

Thinking creatively and helping others to apply creative thinking helps business analysts to be effective in generating new ideas, approaches, and alternatives to problem solving and opportunities.

.2 Definition

Creative thinking involves generating new ideas and concepts as well as finding new or different associations between existing ideas and concepts. It helps

overcome rigid approaches to problem solving by questioning conventional approaches and encouraging new ideas and innovations that are appropriate to the situation. Creative thinking may involve combining, changing, and reapplying existing concepts or ideas. Business analysts can be effective in promoting creative thinking in others by identifying and proposing alternatives, and by asking questions and challenging assumptions.

.3 Effectiveness Measures

Measures of effective creative thinking include:

- generating and productively considering new ideas,
- exploring concepts and ideas that are new,
- exploring changes to existing concepts and ideas,
- generating creativity for self and others, and
- applying new ideas to resolve existing problems.

9.1.2

Decision Making

.1 Purpose

Business analysts must be effective in understanding the criteria involved in making a decision, and in assisting others to make better decisions.

.2 Definition

When a business analyst or a group of stakeholders is faced with having to select an option from a set of alternatives, a decision must be made on which is the most advantageous for the stakeholders and the enterprise. Determining this involves gathering the information that is relevant to the decision, analyzing the relevant information, making comparisons and trade-offs between similar and dissimilar options, and identifying the most desirable option. Business analysts document decisions (and the rationale supporting those decisions) to use them as a reference in the event a similar decision is required in the future or if they are required to explain why a decision was made.

.3 Effectiveness Measures

Measures of effective decision making include:

- the appropriate stakeholders are represented in the decision-making process,
- stakeholders understand the decision-making process and the rationale behind the decision,
- the pros and cons of all available options are clearly communicated to stakeholders,
- the decision reduces or eliminates uncertainty, and any remaining uncertainty is accepted,

- the decision made addresses the need or the opportunity at hand and is in the best interest of all stakeholders,
- stakeholders understand all the conditions, environment, and measures in which the decision will be made, and
- a decision is made.

9.1.3 Learning

.1 Purpose

The ability to quickly absorb new and different types of information and also modify and adapt existing knowledge allows business analysts to work effectively in rapidly changing and evolving environments.

.2 Definition

Learning is the process of gaining knowledge or skills. Learning about a domain passes through a set of stages, from initial acquisition and learning of raw facts, through comprehension of their meaning, to applying the knowledge in day-to-day work, and finally analysis, synthesis, and evaluation. Business analysts must be able to describe their level of understanding of the business domain and be capable of applying that level of understanding to determine which analysis activities need to be performed in a given situation. Once learning about a domain has reached the point where analysis is complete, business analysts must be able to synthesize the information to identify opportunities to create new solutions and evaluate those solutions to ensure that they are effective.

Learning is improved when the learning technique is selected based on the required learning outcomes.

Learning techniques to consider include:

- **Visual:** learning through the presentation of pictures, photographs, diagrams, models, and videos.
- **Auditory:** learning through verbal and written language and text.
- **Kinesthetic:** learning by doing.

Most people experience faster understanding and longer retention of information when more than one learning technique is used.

.3 Effectiveness Measures

Measures of effective learning include:

- understanding that learning is a process for all stakeholders,
- learning the concepts presented and then demonstrating an understanding of them,
- demonstrating the ability to apply concepts to new areas or relationships,
- rapidly absorbing new facts, ideas, concepts, and opinions, and

- effectively presenting new facts, ideas, concepts, and opinions to others.

9.1.4 Problem Solving

.1 Purpose

Business analysts define and solve problems in order to ensure that the real, underlying root cause of a problem is understood by all stakeholders and that solution options address that root cause.

.2 Definition

Defining a problem involves ensuring that the nature of the problem and any underlying issues are clearly understood by all stakeholders. Stakeholder points of view are articulated and addressed to understand any conflicts between the goals and objectives of different groups of stakeholders. Assumptions are identified and validated. The objectives that will be met once the problem is solved are clearly specified, and alternative solutions are considered and possibly developed. Alternatives are measured against the objectives to determine which possible solution is best, and identify the value and trade-offs that may exist between solutions.

.3 Effectiveness Measures

Measures of effective problem solving include:

- confidence of the participants in the problem solving process,
- selected solutions meet the defined objectives and solve the root cause of the problem,
- new solution options can be evaluated effectively using the problem solving framework, and
- the problem solving process avoids making decisions based on unvalidated assumptions, preconceived notions, or other traps that may cause a sub-optimal solution to be selected.

9.1.5 Systems Thinking

.1 Purpose

Understanding how the people, processes, and technology within an organization interact allows business analysts to understand the enterprise from a holistic point of view.

.2 Definition

Systems theory and systems thinking suggest that a system as a whole has properties, behaviours, and characteristics that emerge from the interaction of the components of that system. These factors are not predictable from an understanding of the components alone. For example, just because a business

analyst knows that a customer may return an item they purchased doesn't give the business analyst the full picture. The analyst must analyze the impact the return has on such items as inventory, finance, and store clerk training. In the context of systems theory, the term system includes the people involved, the interactions between them, the external forces affecting their behaviour, and all other relevant elements and factors.

.3 Effectiveness Measures

Measures of effective use of systems thinking include:

- communicating how a change to a component affects the system as a whole,
- communicating how a change to a system affects the environment it is in, and
- communicating how systems adapt to internal and/or external pressures and changes.

9.1.6

Conceptual Thinking

.1 Purpose

Business analysts routinely receive large amounts of detailed and potentially disparate information. They apply conceptual thinking skills to find ways to understand how that information fits into a larger picture and what details are important, and to connect seemingly abstract information.

.2 Definition

Conceptual thinking is about understanding the linkage between contexts, solutions, needs, changes, stakeholders, and value abstractly and in the big picture. It involves understanding and connecting information and patterns that may not be obviously related. Conceptual thinking involves understanding where details fit into a larger context. It involves using past experiences, knowledge, creativity, intuition, and abstract thinking to generate alternatives, options, and ideas that are not easily defined or related.

Conceptual thinking in business analysis is specifically about linking factors not easily defined to the underlying problem or opportunity, models, or frameworks that help stakeholders understand and facilitate themselves and others through change. It is needed to connect disparate information from a multitude of stakeholders, objectives, risks, details, and other factors. With this information it generates options and alternatives for a solution, and communicates this information to others while encouraging them to generate ideas of their own.

.3 Effectiveness Measures

Measures of effective conceptual thinking include:

- connecting disparate information and acting to better understand the relationship,

- confirming the confidence and understanding of the concept being communicated with stakeholders,
- formulating abstract concepts using a combination of information and uncertainty, and
- drawing on past experiences to understand the situation.

9.1.7 Visual Thinking

.1 Purpose

The ability to communicate complex concepts and models into understandable visual representations allows business analysts to engage stakeholders and help them understand the concepts being presented.

.2 Definition

Visual thinking skills allow business analysts to create graphical representations of the concepts or systems being discussed. The goal of these graphical representations is to allow stakeholders to easily understand the concepts being presented, and then provide input. Visual thinking requires that the analyst make abstractions and then find suitable graphic devices to represent them.

Visual thinking is visualizing and creating simple visual concepts, graphics, models, diagrams, and constructs to convey and integrate non-visual information. In performing business analysis, large amounts of information and complex connections between contexts, stakeholders, needs, solutions, changes, and value are communicated. Visuals represent this information and its complexities, allowing stakeholders and audiences to learn more quickly, process the information, and connect points from each of their contexts.

Visual thinking also allows the audience to engage and connect concepts more quickly and freely into their context, as well as understand and appreciate others' contexts more clearly.

.3 Effectiveness Measures

Measures of effective visual thinking include:

- complex information is communicated in a visual model which is understandable by stakeholders,
- visuals allow for comparisons, pattern finding, and idea mapping with participants,
- productivity increases due to increased learning, quick memory, and follow through from effective visuals,
- stakeholders are engaged at a deeper level than with text alone, and
- stakeholders understand critical information which may have been missed if presented in textual content alone.

9.2 Behavioural Characteristics

Behavioural characteristics are not unique to business analysis but they have been found to increase personal effectiveness in the practice of business analysis. These characteristics exist at the core of every business analyst's skill set. Each of the behavioural characteristics described here can impact the outcome of the practitioner's efforts.

The core competencies of behavioural characteristics focus on the skills and behaviours that allow a business analyst to gain the trust and respect of stakeholders. Business analysts do this by consistently acting in an ethical manner, completing tasks on time and to expectations, efficiently delivering quality results, and demonstrating adaptability to changing needs and circumstances.

Behavioural Characteristics core competencies include:

- Ethics (p. 194),
- Personal Accountability (p. 195),
- Trustworthiness (p. 195),
- Organization and Time Management (p. 196), and
- Adaptability (p. 197).

9.2.1 Ethics

.1 Purpose

Behaving ethically and thinking of ethical impacts on others allows business analysts to earn the respect of the stakeholders. The ability to recognize when a proposed solution or requirement may present ethical difficulties to an organization or its stakeholders is an important consideration that business analysts can use to help reduce exposure to risk.

.2 Definition

Ethics require an understanding and focus on fairness, consideration, and moral behaviour through business analysis activities and relationships. Ethical behaviour includes consideration of the impact that a proposed solution can have on all stakeholder groups and working to ensure that those groups are treated as fairly as possible. Fair treatment does not require that the outcome be beneficial to a particular stakeholder group, but it does require that the affected stakeholders understand the reasons for decisions. Awareness of ethical issues allows business analysts to identify when ethical dilemmas occur and recommend resolutions to these dilemmas.

.3 Effectiveness Measures

Measures of effective ethical behaviour include:

- prompt identification and resolution of ethical dilemmas,
- feedback from stakeholders confirming they feel decisions and actions are transparent and fair,

- decisions made with consideration of the interests of all stakeholders,
- reasoning for decisions that is clearly articulated and understood,
- full and prompt disclosure of potential conflicts of interest, and
- honesty regarding one's abilities, the performance of one's work, and accepting responsibility for failures or errors.

9.2.2 Personal Accountability

.1 Purpose

Personal accountability is important for a business analyst because it ensures business analysis tasks are completed on time and to the expectations of colleagues and stakeholders. It enables the business analyst to establish credibility by ensuring that business analysis efforts meet the needs of the business.

.2 Description

Personal accountability includes effectively planning business analysis work to achieve targets and goals, and ensuring that value delivered is aligned with business needs. It involves chasing down all leads and loose ends to fully satisfy the stakeholder's needs. Following through on and fully completing business analysis tasks produces complete, accurate, and relevant solutions traceable to a need. Business analysts take responsibility for identifying and escalating risks and issues. They also ensure that decision makers have the appropriate information in order to assess impact.

.3 Effectiveness Measures

Measures of effective personal accountability include:

- work effort is planned and easily articulated to others,
- work is completed as planned or re-planned with sufficient reasoning and lead time,
- status of both planned and unplanned work is known,
- stakeholders feel that work is organized,
- risks and issues are identified and appropriately acted on,
- completely traceable requirements are delivered on time, and stakeholder needs are met.

9.2.3 Trustworthiness

.1 Purpose

Earning the trust of stakeholders helps business analysts elicit business analysis information around sensitive issues and enables them to help stakeholders have confidence that their recommendations will be evaluated properly and fairly.

.2 Description

Trustworthiness is the perception that one is worthy of trust. A business analyst being considered trustworthy may offset the natural fear of change experienced by many stakeholders.

Several factors can contribute to being considered trustworthy:

- intentionally and consistently completing tasks and deliverables on time, within budget, and achieving expected results so that colleagues and stakeholders consider the business analyst's behaviour dependable and diligent,
- presenting a consistent attitude of confidence, so that colleagues and stakeholders consider the business analyst's demeanor as strong,
- acting in an honest and straightforward manner, addressing conflict and concerns immediately so that colleagues and stakeholders consider the business analyst's morals as being honest and transparent, and
- maintaining a consistent schedule over a long period of time so that colleagues and stakeholders consider the business analyst's availability predictable and reliable.

.3 Effectiveness Measures

Measures of effective trustworthiness include:

- stakeholders involve the business analyst in discussions and decision making,
- stakeholders bring issues and concerns to the business analyst,
- stakeholders are willing to discuss difficult or controversial topics with the business analyst,
- stakeholders do not blame the business analyst when problems occur,
- stakeholders respect the business analyst's ideas and referrals, and
- stakeholders respond to the business analyst's referrals with positive feedback.

9.2.4 Organization and Time Management

.1 Purpose

Organization and time management skills help business analysts perform tasks effectively and use work time efficiently.

.2 Description

Organization and time management involves the ability to prioritize tasks, perform them efficiently, and manage time effectively. Business analysts are constantly acquiring and accumulating significant quantities of information, and

this information must be organized and stored in an efficient manner so that it can be used and reused at a later date. Business analysts must also be able to differentiate important information that should be retained from less important information.

Effective time management requires the ability to prioritize tasks and deadlines.

Techniques of organization include establishing short- and long-term goals, action plans, prioritizing tasks, and utilizing a checklist. Techniques for effective time management include establishing time limits on non-critical tasks, focusing more time on high risk and priority tasks, setting aside focus time, and managing potential interruptions.

.3 Effectiveness Measures

Measures of effective organization and time management include:

- the ability to produce deliverables in a timely manner,
- stakeholders feel that the business analyst focuses on the correct tasks at the right time,
- schedule of work effort and deadlines is managed and communicated to stakeholders,
- stakeholders feel their time in meetings and in reading communications is well spent,
- complete preparation for meetings, interviews, and requirements workshops,
- relevant business analysis information is captured, organized, and documented,
- adherence to the project schedule and the meeting of deadlines,
- provides accurate, thorough, and concise information in a logical manner which is understood by stakeholders, and
- maintains up-to-date information on the status of each work item and all outstanding work.

9.2.5

Adaptability

.1 Purpose

Business analysts frequently work in rapidly changing environments and with a variety of stakeholders. They adjust their behavioural style and method of approach to increase their effectiveness when interacting with different stakeholders, organizations, and situations.

.2 Definition

Adaptability is the ability to change techniques, style, methods, and approach. By demonstrating a willingness to interact with and complete tasks in a manner

preferable to the stakeholders, business analysts can maximize the quality of service delivered and more efficiently help the organization achieve its goals and objectives. Having the curiosity to learn what others need and possessing the courage to try a different behaviour is adapting to situations and context.

Business analysts sometimes have to modify the way they interact with stakeholders, such as the way they conduct interviews or the way they facilitate workshops. Different stakeholders have different levels of comfort with techniques that are in the business analysis tool kit. Some stakeholders are more visual and respond better to information that is represented visually in models, diagrams, and pictures. Other stakeholders are more verbal and prefer textual descriptions. Being able to determine which techniques will work and which will not, and then adapt accordingly increases the likelihood of a successful interaction.

In the event that the goals and objectives of the organization change, business analysts respond by accepting the changes and adapting to a new mandate. Similarly, when circumstances arise or unanticipated problems occur, business analysts adapt by altering their plans and identifying options that can be used to deliver maximum value. The business analyst adapts when the business or stakeholder needs change, or when the context of the goal or the objective changes. When the need itself changes, the business analyst adapts by altering the plans and the approach in order to ensure that value is provided and delivered as part of the solution.

.3 Effectiveness Measures

Measures of effective adaptability include:

- demonstrating the courage to act differently from others,
- adapting to changing conditions and environments,
- valuing and considering other points of view and approaches,
- demonstrating a positive attitude in the face of ambiguity and change,
- demonstrating a willingness to learn new methods, procedures, or techniques in order to accomplish goals and objectives,
- changing behaviour to perform effectively under changing or unclear conditions,
- acquiring and applying new information and skills to address new challenges,
- acceptance of having changes made to tasks, roles and project assignments as organizational realities change,
- altering interpersonal style to highly diverse individuals and groups in a range of situations, and
- evaluating what worked, what did not, and what could be done differently next time.

9.3 Business Knowledge

Business knowledge is required for the business analyst to perform effectively within their business, industry, organization, solution, and methodology. Business knowledge enables the business analyst to better understand the overarching concepts that govern the structure, benefits, and value of the situation as it relates to a change or a need.

Business Knowledge underlying competencies include:

- Business Acumen (p. 199),
- Industry Knowledge (p. 200),
- Organization Knowledge (p. 201),
- Solution Knowledge (p. 202), and
- Methodology Knowledge (p. 202).

9.3.1 Business Acumen

.1 Purpose

Business analysis requires an understanding of fundamental business principles and best practices in order to ensure they are considered as solutions are reviewed.

.2 Description

Business acumen is the ability to understand business needs using experience and knowledge obtained from other situations. Organizations frequently share similar practices, such as legal and regulatory requirements, finance, logistics, sales, marketing, supply chain management, human resources, and technology. Business acumen is the ability to understand and apply the knowledge based on these commonalities within differing situations.

Understanding how other organizations have solved challenges may be useful when seeking possible solutions. Being aware of the experiences or challenges encountered in the past may assist a business analyst in determining which information may be applicable to the current situation. Factors that may cause differences in practices can include industry, location, size of organization, culture, and the maturity of the organization.

.3 Effectiveness Measures

Measures of effective business acumen include:

- demonstrating the ability to recognize potential limitations and opportunities,
- demonstrating the ability to recognize when changes to a situation may require a change in the direction of an initiative or effort,

- understanding the risks involved and the ability to make decisions on managing risks,
- demonstrating the ability to recognize an opportunity to decrease expenses and increase profits, and
- understanding the options available to address emerging changes in the situation.

9.3.2 Industry Knowledge

.1 Purpose

Industry knowledge provides the business analyst with an understanding of current practices and activities within an industry, and similar processes across industries.

.2 Description

Industry knowledge is an understanding of:

- current trends,
- market forces,
- market drivers,
- key processes,
- services,
- products,
- definitions,
- customer segments,
- suppliers,
- practices,
- regulations, and
- other factors that impact or are impacted by the industry and related industries.

Industry knowledge is also an understanding of how a company is positioned within an industry, and its impacts and dependencies, in regards to the market and human resources.

When developing knowledge about a particular industry, competitor, or company the following set of questions can provide guidance:

- Who are the top leaders in the industry?
- Which organizations promote or regulate the industry?
- What are the benefits of being involved with these organizations?
- Who is creating publicity releases, participating in conventions, and delivering marketing materials?
- What are the comparisons of products and services?
- What are the satisfaction indicators/benchmarking projects that are applicable?
- What are the suppliers, practices, equipment and tools used by each company, and why do they use them?

- What are the potential impacts of weather, political unrest, or natural disasters?
- Who are the target customers and are they the same for the competition?
- What impacts the seasonal cycles for production, marketing, and sales? Does it impact staffing or require changes in processes?

.3 Effectiveness Measures

Measures of effective industry knowledge include:

- being aware of activities within both the enterprise and the broader industry,
- having knowledge of major competitors and partners,
- the ability to identify key trends shaping the industry,
- being familiar with the largest customer segments,
- having knowledge of common products and product types,
- being knowledgeable of sources of information about the industry, including relevant trade organizations or journals,
- understanding of industry specific terms, standards, processes and methodologies, and
- understanding of the industry regulatory environment.

9.3.3 Organization Knowledge

.1 Purpose

Organization knowledge provides an understanding of the management structure and business architecture of the enterprise.

.2 Definition

Organization knowledge includes an understanding of how the enterprise generates profits, accomplishes its goals, its organizational structure, the relationships that exist between business units, and the persons who occupy key stakeholder positions. Organization knowledge also includes understanding the organization's formal and informal communication channels as well as an awareness of the internal politics that influence decision making.

.3 Effectiveness Measures

Measures of effective organization knowledge include:

- the ability to act according to informal and formal communications and authority channels,
- understanding of terminology or jargon used in the organization,
- understanding of the products or services offered by the organization,

- the ability to identify subject matter experts (SMEs) in the organization, and
- the ability to navigate organizational relationships and politics.

9.3.4 Solution Knowledge

.1 Purpose

Solution knowledge allows business analysts to leverage their understanding of existing departments, environments, or technology to efficiently identify the most effective means of implementing a change.

.2 Definition

When the business analysis effort involves improving an existing solution, business analysts apply knowledge and experience from the previous work on the solution. Familiarity with the range of commercially available solutions or suppliers can assist with the identification of possible alternatives. The business analyst may leverage knowledge gained from prior experiences to expedite the discovery of potential changes through elicitation or in-depth analysis.

.3 Effectiveness Measures

Measures of effective solution knowledge include:

- reduced time or cost to implement a required change,
- shortened time on requirements analysis and/or solution design,
- understanding when a larger change is, or is not, justified based on business benefit, and
- understanding how additional capabilities that are present, but not currently used, can be deployed to provide value.

9.3.5 Methodology Knowledge

.1 Purpose

Understanding the methodologies used by the organization provides the business analyst with information regarding context, dependencies, opportunities, and constraints used when developing a business analysis approach.

.2 Description

Methodologies determine the timing (big steps or small increments), the approach, the role of those involved, the accepted risk level, and other aspects of how a change is approached and managed. Organizations adopt or create their own methodologies to fit varying levels of culture, maturity, adaptability, risk, uncertainty, and governance.

Knowledge regarding a variety of methodologies allows the business analyst to quickly adapt to, and perform in, new environments.

.3 Effectiveness Measures

Measures of effective methodology knowledge include:

- the ability to adapt to changes in methodologies,
- the willingness to use or learn a new methodology,
- the successful integration of business analysis tasks and techniques to support the current methodology,
- familiarity with the terms, tools, and techniques prescribed by a methodology, and
- the ability to play multiple roles within activities prescribed by a methodology.

9.4

Communication Skills

Communication is the act of a sender conveying information to a receiver in a method which delivers the meaning the sender intended. Active listening skills help to deepen understanding and trust between the sender and the receiver. Effective communication benefits all stakeholders.

Communication may be accomplished using a variety of delivery methods: verbal, non-verbal, physical, and written. Most communication methods deal with words, while some methods deal with movements and expressions. Words, gestures, and phrases may have different meanings to different individuals. Effective communication involves both the sender and receiver possessing the same understanding of the information being communicated. A shared glossary of terms and clear goals are effective tools to avoid misunderstandings and the resulting complications.

Effective communication includes adapting communication styles and techniques to the knowledge level and communication styles of recipients. Effective communicators understand how tone, body language, and context change the meaning of words. Gaining an understanding of the terms and concepts (prior to the exchange) can provide fruitful benefits.

Planning effective communication includes the sender reviewing the information that is known about the receiver. Differences between the sender and the receiver, such as native language, culture, motivations, priorities, communication, learning, and thinking styles may call for specific communication methods. Each piece of information must be carefully crafted and packaged to ensure it is clear and understood.

When planning to communicate information, the following considerations may be helpful:

- consider what the receiver knows or does not know,
- structure the information in a logical, comprehensible manner,
- determine how to best present the information to convey the intended

meanings (for example, using visual aids, graphs, diagrams, or bullet points), and

- understand the expectations of the recipients.

Communication Skills core competencies include:

- Verbal Communication (p. 204),
- Non-Verbal Communication (p. 205),
- Written Communication (p. 205), and
- Listening (p. 206).

9.4.1

Verbal Communication

.1 Purpose

Business analysts use verbal communication to convey ideas, concepts, facts, and opinions to a variety of stakeholders.

.2 Description

Verbal communication uses spoken words to convey information from the sender to the receiver. Verbal communication skills are used to express business analysis information, ideas, concepts, facts, and opinions. It allows for the efficient transfer of information, including emotional and other non-verbal cues. It can be paired with both written and non-verbal communication.

Verbal communication deals specifically with the sender's choice of words and the tone of voice. When the receiver is able to see the sender, the sender's non-verbal communication impacts the meaning of the message being understood by the receiver. When the sender is able to see the receiver, the receiver is providing a response and both the sender and receiver are engaged in a dialogue, even though the receiver may not be speaking verbally. Monitoring the receiver's non-verbal communication allows the sender to consider adapting the message for the receiver.

Having an understanding of the tone of the communication and how it can positively or negatively influence the listener allows the business analyst to more effectively communicate verbally. Effective verbal communication skills include the ability to make one's meaning understood. The sender should partner verbal communication with active listening to ensure that information presented is being understood by the receiver.

.3 Effectiveness Measures

Measures of effective verbal communication include:

- restating concepts to ensure all stakeholders clearly understand the same information,
- assisting conversations to reach productive conclusions,

- delivering effective presentations by designing and positioning content and objectives appropriately, and
- communicating an issue's important points in a calm and rational manner, and presenting solution options.

9.4.2 Non-Verbal Communication

.1 Purpose

Non-verbal communication skills enable the effective sending and receiving of messages through—but not limited to—body movement, posture, facial expressions, gestures, and eye contact.

.2 Definition

Communication is typically focused upon words that are written or spoken. Non-verbal communication, however, is believed to convey much more meaning than words alone. Moods, attitudes, and feelings impact body movement and facial expressions. Non-verbal communication begins immediately when one person is able to see another. The effective use of non-verbal communication skills can present a trustworthy, confident, and capable demeanor. Being aware of non-verbal communication provides the opportunity to be aware and address the feelings of others that are not expressed verbally.

Observing gestures or expressions cannot provide a complete understanding of the message being expressed by these non-verbal cues. These cues are indicators of the feelings and intent of the communicator. For example, when a stakeholder's non-verbal communication does not agree with their verbal message, the business analyst may want to explore the conversation further to uncover the source of this disagreement.

.3 Effectiveness Measures

Measures of effective non-verbal communication include:

- being aware of body language in others, but not assuming a complete understanding through non-verbal communication,
- intentional awareness of personal non-verbal communication,
- improving trust and communication as a result of non-verbal communication, and
- effectively addressing and resolving situations when a stakeholder's non-verbal communication does not agree with their verbal message.

9.4.3 Written Communication

.1 Purpose

Business analysts use written communication to convey ideas, concepts, facts, and opinions to variety of stakeholders.

.2 Definition

Written communication is the practice of using text, symbols, models (formal or informal), and sketches to convey and share information. An understanding of the audience is beneficial to effectively use written communication. Presenting information and ideas requires selecting the correct words so the audience will understand the intended meaning. Written communication has the added challenge of presenting information at a time or place that is remote from the time and place it was created.

Effective written communication requires a broad vocabulary, strong grasp of grammar and style, and an understanding of the terms which will be understood by the audience. Written communication has the potential to convey a great deal of information; however, conveying information effectively is a skill which must be developed.

.3 Effectiveness Measures

Measures of effective written communication include:

- adjusting the style of writing for the needs of the audience,
- proper use of grammar and style,
- choosing words the audience will understand the intended meaning of, and
- ability of the reader to paraphrase and describe the content of the written communication.

9.4.4

Listening

.1 Purpose

Effective listening allows the business analyst to accurately understand information that is communicated verbally.

.2 Definition

Listening is the process of not just hearing words but understanding their meaning in context. By exhibiting effective listening skills, business analysts not only have a greater opportunity to accurately understand what is being communicated, but also to demonstrate that they think what the speaker is saying is important.

Active listening involves both listening and interpreting what the other person is trying to communicate beyond the words used in order to understand the essence of the message. Active listening includes summarizing and repeating what was stated in different terms in order to ensure that both the listener and the speaker have the same understanding.

.3 Effectiveness Measures

Measures of effective listening include:

- giving the speaker undivided attention,

- acknowledging the speaker with verbal or non-verbal encouragement,
- providing feedback to the person or the group that is speaking to ensure there is an understanding, and
- using active listening skills by deferring judgment and responding appropriately.

9.5 Interaction Skills

Interaction skills are represented by the business analyst's ability to relate, cooperate, and communicate with different kinds of people including executives, sponsors, colleagues, team members, developers, vendors, learning and development professionals, end users, customers, and subject matter experts (SMEs).

Business analysts are uniquely positioned to facilitate stakeholder communication, provide leadership, encourage comprehension of solution value, and promote stakeholder support of the proposed changes.

Interaction Skills core competencies include:

- Facilitation (p. 207),
- Leadership and Influencing (p. 208),
- Teamwork (p. 209),
- Negotiation and Conflict Resolution (p. 210), and
- Teaching (p. 210).

9.5.1 Facilitation

.1 Purpose

Business analysts facilitate interactions between stakeholders in order to help them make a decision, solve a problem, exchange ideas and information, or reach an agreement regarding the priority and the nature of requirements. The business analyst may also facilitate interactions between stakeholders for the purposes of negotiation and conflict resolution (as discussed in Negotiation and Conflict Resolution (p. 210)).

.2 Definition

Facilitation is the skill of moderating discussions within a group in order to enable all participants to effectively articulate their views on a topic under discussion, and to ensure that participants in the discussion are able to recognize and appreciate the differing points of view that are articulated.

.3 Effectiveness Measures

Measures of effective facilitation include:

- making it clear to the participants that the facilitator is a third party to the process and not a decision maker nor the owner of the topic,
- encouraging participation from all attendees,
- remaining neutral and not taking sides, but at the same time being impartial and intervening when required in order to make suggestions and offer insights,
- establishing ground rules such as being open to suggestions, building on what is there, not dismissing ideas, and allowing others to speak and express themselves,
- ensuring that participants in a discussion correctly understand each other's positions,
- using meeting management skills and tools to keep discussions focused and organized,
- preventing discussions from being sidetracked onto irrelevant topics, and
- understanding and considering all parties' interests, motivations, and objectives.

9.5.2 Leadership and Influencing

.1 Purpose

Business analysts use leadership and influencing skills when guiding stakeholders during the investigation of business analysis information and solution options. They build consensus and encourage stakeholder support and collaboration during change.

.2 Definition

Leadership and influencing involves motivating people to act in ways that enable them to work together to achieve shared goals and objectives. Understanding the individual motives, needs, and capabilities of each stakeholder and how those can be effectively channeled assists business analysts in meeting the shared objectives of the organization. The business analyst's responsibility for defining, analyzing, and communicating business analysis information provides opportunities for leadership and influencing, whether or not there are people formally reporting to the business analyst.

.3 Effectiveness Measures

Measures of effective leadership and influencing include:

- reduced resistance to necessary changes,
- articulation of a clear and inspiring vision of a desired future state,
- success in inspiring others to turn vision into action,

- influence on stakeholders to understand mutual interests,
- effective use of collaboration techniques to influence others,
- influence on stakeholders to consider broader objectives over personal motivations, and
- re-framing issues so alternate perspectives can be understood and accommodated to influence stakeholders towards shared goals.

9.5.3 Teamwork

.1 Purpose

Teamwork skills allow business analysts to work productively with team members, stakeholders, and any other vested partners so that solutions can be effectively developed and implemented.

.2 Definition

Business analysts often work as part of a team with other business analysts, project managers, stakeholders, and subject matter experts (SMEs). Relationships with people in those roles are a critical part of the success of any project or enterprise. It is important for the business analyst to understand how a team is formed and how it functions. Recognizing team dynamics and how they play a part as the team progresses through various stages of a project is also crucial. Knowing and adapting to how and when a team is progressing through a project's life cycle can lower the negative influences that impact a team.

Building and maintaining trust of teammates contributes to the integrity of the team as a whole and helps the team perform at its fullest capacity. When team members actively foster an environment for positive and trusting team dynamics, difficult decisions and challenges become less complicated.

Team conflict is common. If handled well, the resolution of conflict can benefit the team. Resolving conflict requires the team to focus on examining the positions, assumptions, observations, and expectations of all team members. Working through such problems can have the beneficial effect of strengthening the foundation of the analysis and the solution.

.3 Effectiveness Measures

Measures of effective teamwork include:

- fostering a collaborative working environment,
- effectively resolving conflict,
- developing trust among team members,
- support among the team for shared high standards of achievement, and
- promoting a shared sense of ownership of the team goals.

9.5.4 Negotiation and Conflict Resolution

.1 Purpose

Business analysts occasionally mediate negotiations between stakeholders in order to reach a common understanding or an agreement. During this process, business analysts help resolve conflicts and differences of opinion with the intent of maintaining and strengthening working relationships among stakeholders and team members.

.2 Definition

Negotiation and conflict resolution involves mediating discussions between participants in order to help them recognize that there are differing views on the topic, resolve differences, and reach conclusions that have the agreement of all participants. Successful negotiation and conflict resolution includes identifying the underlying interests of the parties, distinguishing those interests from their stated positions, and helping the parties identify solutions that satisfy those underlying interests. The business analyst accomplishes this while ensuring that the outcome of the resolution aligns with the overall solution and the business needs.

.3 Effectiveness Measures

Measures of effective negotiation and conflict resolution include:

- a planned approach to ensure that the negotiation takes into account the tone of voice, the conveyed attitude, the methods used, and the concern for the other side's feelings and needs,
- the ability to recognize that the needs of the parties are not always in opposition and that it is often possible to satisfy both parties without either side losing,
- an objective approach to ensure the problem is separated from the person so that the real issues are debated without damaging working relationships, and
- the ability to recognize that effective negotiation and conflict resolution are not always achieved in a single autonomous meeting, and that sometimes several meetings are required in order to achieve the stated goals.

9.5.5 Teaching

.1 Purpose

Teaching skills help business analysts effectively communicate business analysis information, concepts, ideas, and issues. They also help ensure that information is understood and retained by stakeholders.

.2 Definition

Teaching is the process of leading others to gain knowledge. Business analysts are responsible for confirming that the information communicated has been

understood by stakeholders. Business analysts lead stakeholders to discover clarity in ambiguity by helping them learn about the contexts and value of the needs being investigated. This requires teaching skills in selecting the most appropriate visual, verbal, written, and kinesthetic teaching approaches according to the information or techniques being taught. The intent is to draw out stakeholder engagement and collaborative learning to gain clarity. Business analysts frequently elicit and learn new information, and then teach this information to stakeholders in a meaningful way.

.3 Effectiveness Measures

Measures of effective teaching include:

- utilizing different methods to communicate information to be learned by stakeholders,
- discovering new information through high levels of stakeholder engagement,
- validating that audiences have a clear understanding of the key messages that are intended to be learned, and
- verifying that the stakeholders can demonstrate the new knowledge, facts, concepts, and ideas.

9.6

Tools and Technology

Business analysts use a variety of software applications to support communication and collaboration, create and maintain requirements artifacts, model concepts, track issues, and increase overall productivity.

Requirements documentation is often developed using word processing tools, while the process of developing business requirements may require the use of prototyping and simulation tools, as well as specialized tools for modelling and diagramming.

Requirements management technologies support requirements workflow, approvals, baselining, and change control. These technologies can also support the traceability between requirements and assist in determining the impact of changes to requirements.

Interacting with the stakeholders and team members may require the use of communication and collaboration tools, as well as presentation software in order to showcase ideas and generate discussion among stakeholders and team members.

Business Analysis Tools and Technology core competencies include:

- Office Productivity Tools and Technology (p. 212),
- Business Analysis Tools and Technology (p. 213), and
- Communication Tools and Technology (p. 215).

9.6.1 Office Productivity Tools and Technology

.1 Purpose

Business analysts use office productivity tools and technology to document and track information and artifacts.

.2 Definition

Office productivity tools and technology provide business analysts with the ability to organize, dissect, manipulate, understand, and communicate information clearly. Utilizing these tools requires becoming familiar with available resources. Understanding one software program may provide insights into comparable abilities or operations in similar programs. Additionally, some programs are designed to provide additional tools to other programs or exchange information, such as e-mail or programs that can import/export files. Many organizations utilize these tools to study, store, and distribute information.

Office productivity tools and technology include the following:

- **Word processing and presentation programs:** provide the ability to present information in the form of a letter, newspaper, poster, research paper, slide presentation, or animations. Word processors are commonly used to develop and maintain requirements documents, allowing a great deal of control over their formatting and presentation. Standard requirements documentation templates are widely available for word processors. Most word processing tools have a limited capability to track changes and record comments, and are not designed for collaborative authoring; however, there are cloud solutions that provide collaborative functionality.
- **Presentation software:** serves in the creation of training materials or to present information to stimulate discussion among stakeholders. Some of these applications can be used in a very limited way to capture requirements or create a basic prototype.
- **Spreadsheets:** allow mathematical and logical manipulation. They are often used to maintain lists (such as atomic requirements, features, actions, issues, or defects). They are also used to capture and perform basic manipulation of numeric data. They can support decision analysis, and are very effective at summarizing complex scenarios. They support limited change tracking and can be shared among multiple users in the same way as a word processing document.
- **Communication tools (e-mail and instant messaging programs):** provide the means to communicate with stakeholders who are remotely located, who cannot respond to queries immediately, or who may need a longer-term record of a discussion. They are generally available to almost all stakeholders and are very easy to use. However, they are generally not effective for long-term storage or retention of information. Their primary use is to facilitate communication over time or distance.
- **Collaboration and knowledge management tools:** support the capturing of knowledge distributed throughout an organization and make it as widely

available as possible. They allow documents to be accessible by an entire team, and facilitate collaboration. They also enable multiple users to work on a document simultaneously, and generally support comments and discussion about document content. These tools may take the form of a document repository (which integrates with office productivity software), wikis (which allow easy creation and linking of web pages), discussion forums, cloud services, or other web-based tools.

- **Hardware:** allows for the replication and distribution of information to facilitate communication with stakeholders. Tools such as printers and digital projectors are often used to translate digital information generated on a computer into physical information for ease of use. Photocopiers and scanners copy physical documents and can provide the ability to share them electronically.

.3 Effectiveness Measures

Measures of effective office productivity tools and technology include:

- increased efficiencies and streamlining of processes by exploring features and functions of tools,
- awareness of available tools, their operation, and abilities,
- the ability to determine the tool that will best meet stakeholder needs, and
- the ability to clearly communicate the major features of available tools.

9.6.2

Business Analysis Tools and Technology

.1 Purpose

Business analysts use a variety of tools and technology to model, document, and manage outputs of business analysis activities and deliverables to stakeholders.

.2 Definition

Tools that are specific to the field of business analysis provide specialized capabilities in:

- modelling,
- diagramming,
- documenting,
- analyzing and mapping requirements,
- identifying relationships between requirements,
- tracking and storing requirements artifacts, and
- communicating with stakeholders.

Some business analysis tools and technologies focus solely on a single business analysis activity and some integrate multiple business analysis functions into a single tool. Tools specifically designed for business analysis may include such

functionality as modelling, requirements management, issue tracking, prototyping and simulation, computer aided software engineering (CASE), and survey engines.

Modelling tools can provide functionality that assists business analysts with a number of modelling related tasks, including:

- creating models and visuals to help align stakeholders and outline the relationship of needs, entities, requirements, stakeholders, and context,
- tracing visuals to business rules, text requirements, scope statements, scope visuals, data requirements, product needs, and other requirements context and information, and
- creating an executable for a proprietary engine in order to execute the model or generate an application code which can be enhanced by a developer.

These tools frequently validate compliance with the notation. Some modelling tools support the creation of executable models, such as business process management systems (which allow for the creation of executable process models) and business rules management systems (which allow for the evaluation of captured business rules).

Requirements management technologies can provide functionality that assists business analysts with a number of requirements management related tasks including:

- requirements workflow including baselining, approvals and sign-off, change control, and implementation status,
- traceability including backwards traceability, forwards traceability, relationships between requirements, and impact analysis of requirements change,
- configuration management of requirements and requirements artifacts, and
- verifying the quality of requirements through checking for defined characteristics and relationships.

Issue tracking tools can provide functionality that assists business analysts with a number of issue tracking related tasks such as:

- tracking requirements risks,
- tracking requirements conflicts and issues, and
- tracking defects.

Prototyping and simulation tools can provide functionality that assists business analysts with prototyping or simulating the solution or pieces of the solution.

.3 Effectiveness Measures

Measures of effective business analysis tools and technology include:

- the ability to apply an understanding of one tool and other similar tools,

- being able to identify major tools currently available and describe their strengths, weaknesses, and how they may be used in any given situation,
- understanding of and the ability to use the major features of the tool,
- ability to select a tool or tools that support organizational processes,
- the ability to use the tools to complete requirements-related activities more rapidly than otherwise possible, and
- the ability to track changes to the requirements and their impact on the solution implementation, stakeholders, and value.

9.6.3 Communication Tools and Technology

.1 Purpose

Business analysts use communication tools and technology to perform business analysis activities, manage teams, and collaborate with stakeholders.

.2 Definition

Communication tools are used to plan and complete tasks related to conversational interactions and collaborative interactions. Communication tools allow business analysts to work with virtual and co-located teams.

Understanding the options available with these tools—and knowing how to use various communications tools to complete tasks and utilize various techniques in a variety of collaboration environments—can enable more efficient and accurate communication and more effective decision making. Business analysts select the appropriate tool and technology for the situation and stakeholder group while balancing cost, risk, and value.

Examples of conversation interaction tools include voice communications, instant messaging, online chat, e-mail, blogging, and microblogging.

Examples of collaboration tools include video conferencing, electronic white boarding, wikis, electronic calendars, online brainstorming tools, electronic decision making, electronic voting, document sharing, and idea sharing.

.3 Effectiveness Measures

Measures of effective communication tools and technology include:

- the selection of appropriate and effective tools for the audience and purpose,
- effectively choosing when to use communication technology and when not to,
- the ability to identify tools to meet communication needs, and
- understanding of and the ability to use features of the tool.